removing thorns, fondling a baby, playing with pets like parrots and monkeys, writing a letter, playing on a flute or vina, painting designs on the wall or bedecking themselves in various ways by painting the feet, applying collyrium',[4] gazing in the mirror, carrying a lotus or a water jar, dancing, playfully tugging at an ascetic's beard, holding a manuscript, etc. Other secular sculptures include 'domestic life scenes, teachers and disciples, dancers and musicians', ascetics, royal hunts, marching armies, battle scenes, animals like elephants, parrots, boars, snakes, a 'lion with an armed human rider on the back and a warrior counter-player attacking it from behind', and some mythical animals.[5] There are also many scenes where it's hard to say what's going on.

It helped that the region was blessed with high-quality sandstone, which allowed the carving of fine sculptural details like ornamental jewellery, delicate nails and strands of hair, sheer robes clinging to the skin and a wide palette of moods: delight, serenity, playfulness. In large workshops, amid the sounds of hammers and chisels, master artisans conceived and carved their artwork and taught apprentices. 'A panel kept in the Khajuraho museum depicts a large number of labourers carrying stones with the help of long wooden poles.'[6] Copperplate inscriptions have revealed that artisans got new titles as they acquired greater skill. A skilled artisan was called a *Silpin*, and many an image is inscribed with the names of Silpins. With higher skill, he became a *Vijananin*. A few became adept enough to be called *Vaidagdhi Visvakarman*, who went beyond mere technicalities of craft to the aesthetics of art.[7] Scholars have also identified a sophisticated language of playful puns, allegories, metaphors, hidden meanings and double entendres (*ślesha*) employed by the sculptors in their statues and inscriptions, a custom that also flourished in the poetry of Chandela times.

The Mysteries of Khajuraho's Art

Indeed, what sort of cultural milieu could have produced such explicit depictions that most people today would consider hardcore porn? Did they also make the men and women of ancient Khajuraho blush? Do these erotic sculptures depict the actual sexual tastes and mores of the patrons and the